

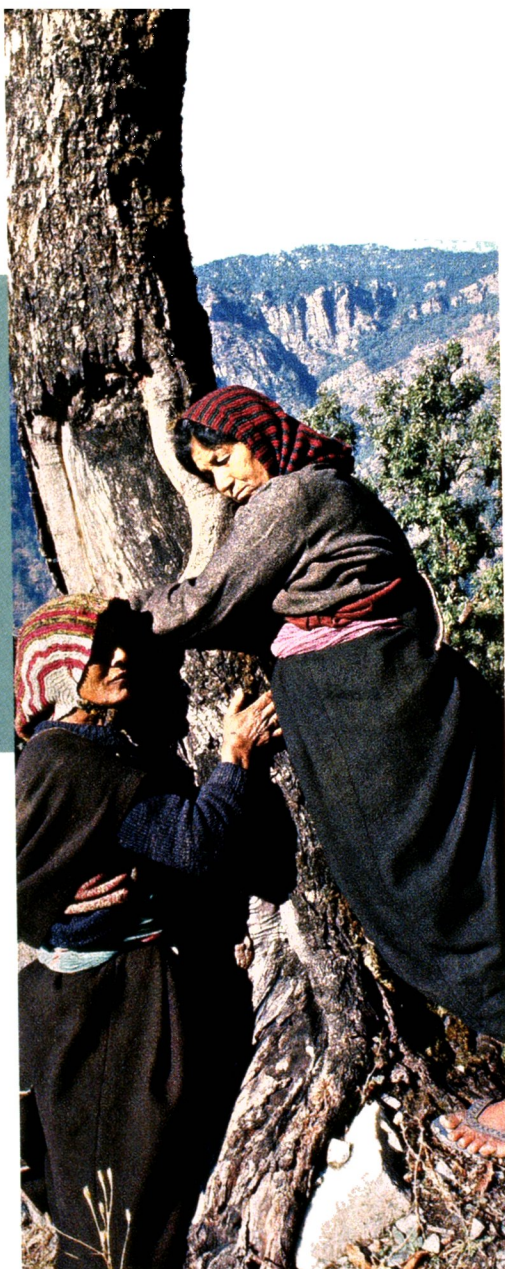
most powerful movements

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Saving the forests of Garhwal by sticking to trees. Fighting a big dam by living in submerged waters. These movements redefined the greening of India

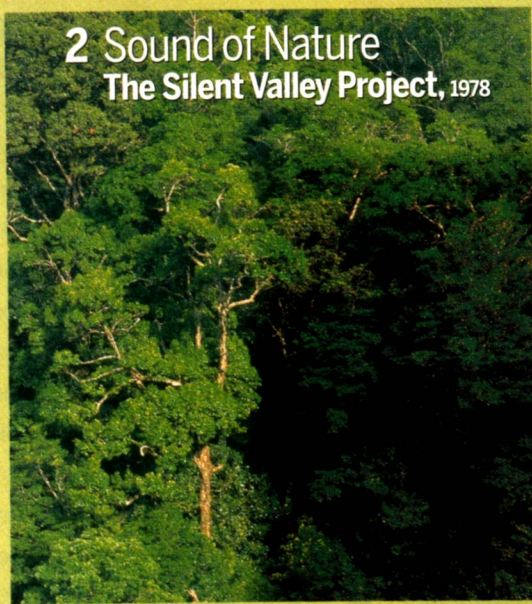
1 Sticking to a Cause Chipko Movement, 1973

"In the wake of reckless deforestation, a unique movement has bubbled," observed INDIA TODAY in March 1982. The 1980s saw the debate on environment move from just deforestation to the larger issues of depletion of natural resources. "Chipko movement in the Garhwal Himalayas, shoved aside urban armchair naturalists. Led by Chandni Prasad Bhatt and Sunderlal Bahuguna, it was a people's revolt against mindless deforestation. And they did it simply. By hugging trees when the woodmen came to axe them," said INDIA TODAY in January 1990.



BHAWAN SINGH

2 Sound of Nature The Silent Valley Project, 1978



HK RAJASHEKHAR

It was a battlefield of personal agendas, between the then prime minister Morarji Desai, the Kerala government and the environmentalists. The Silent Valley hydro-electric project was to dam the Kunthipuzha River, submerging the entire biosphere reserve and destroying its four-million-year-old rainforests. In 1980, the M.G.K. Menon Committee set up to review the project, came out with a recommendation to scrap it. With 40 per cent of its so-called surplus power being supplied to other parts and many villages of Kerala waiting to be electrified, this grassroots movement became the bedrock of Indian environmental activism (INDIA TODAY, August 2003).

3 Rescue Mission Jungle Bachao Andolan, 1980s

"Most states exist in the bliss of ignorance," observed INDIA TODAY in March 1982. It was this observation that led to the birth of the Jungle Bachao Andolan, that began in Bihar and later spread to states like Jharkhand and Orissa. The tribals of Singhbhum district of Bihar bubbled up a protest when the government decided to replace the natural sal forests with highly-priced teak, a move that was termed "a greed game, political populism".

4 Reaping a Change Navdanya Movement, 1982

Whether it's about empowering women or anti-globalisation campaigns, environmental activist Vandana Shiva has always had an upper hand in her fights against the authorities. Her ecofeminist movement reinstated a farming system centred on engaging women, changing the current system. She founded Navdanya in 1982, an organisation promoting biodiversity conservation and organic farming. The organisation has not only helped create markets for farmers, but also promoted quality food for consumers, connecting the seed to the cooked food.